

TEN TOES DOWN PRESENTS

The Panorama of Games for Lillian

VOLUME 5 OF SIX

The Office of People Who Have Something to Tell You

Character stories, dialogue and consequential choices

Forty real games. One wildly unnecessary department.

A comic companion, written by ChatGPT under Nolan's creative direction.

Reader edition 1.0 - 20 September 2026

240 CASES / SIX DEPARTMENTS

ZERO OBLIGATION TO OBEY THE DEPARTMENTS

Before the stamp hits the page

This is an original comic game catalogue inspired by the Aiden ensemble in Ten Toes Down. The source novels remain separate. Game descriptions and catches are research-based editorial notes; Aiden's ministry and rulings are fiction.

The catalogue ranges across possible fits and clearly marked detours. "Waits" describes the usual decision loop, not a certification that every scene is untimed. Promising, conditional and detour are editorial labels, not measurements of anyone's ability. Read the catch on the exact edition.

Choose any game directly. Skip any game for any reason. The elaborate route is an optional joke; declining never costs a token. No purchase, download, account or medical information is needed to use this book.

Print on Letter paper at actual size, or fit to A4. Page references use volume / page, which remain valid in the omnibus. For larger type, use the reflowable EPUB. Links and a full alphabetical index sit beside the printed case numbers.

The six departments

1. Suspiciously Interesting People - mysteries and adventures
2. Taking One's Turn - strategy and role-playing
3. Looking Around Before Doing Anything - exploration
4. Things That Fit Into Other Things - puzzles and construction
5. People Who Have Something to Tell You - character stories
6. Bringing a Friend - co-op and shared play

A route that knows when to shut up

The shortest working procedure

First name up to three real preferences or vetoes: required speed, camera movement, holds, menus, reading, clue tracking or native co-op. Keep them beside you. The route cannot overrule them.

You are in Department 5. Pick one mood row and one emblem column below; neither claims to describe a game feature. That gives a starting case. You can go there now.

For ceremonial excess only, roll four ordinary six-sided dice: 1-2 means minus one; 3-4 means zero; 5-6 means plus one. Add the four results. Add zero, one or two for any already-available wanted drink and wanted snack. Eating is never required.

Begin a browsing session with three imaginary Stamp Tokens. At most once per selection, spend one to add two OR reroll all four dice. You may take an optional funny trait from Book I as your excuse. Never pay a token to refuse a game.

Move that many cases along this department's forty-case shelf, wrapping around at either end. Read the real catch. If you want one appeal, visit the adjacent case or the same local position in another department; then choose freely or stop. No appeal loops.

The printed full rules, worked example and incident desk are in Volume I. The offline index performs the arithmetic and provides conservative evidence filters. The direct alphabetical index at the back always works without dice.

Mood / emblem	1. Envelope	2. Key	3. Plant	4. Map	5. Teacup	6. Spare chair	7. Gold stamp	8. Clock
1. Quietly curious	P161	P162	P163	P164	P165	P166	P167	P168
2. Ready for conversation	P169	P170	P171	P172	P173	P174	P175	P176
3. Willing to inspect a thing	P177	P178	P179	P180	P181	P182	P183	P184
4. Here for the atmosphere	P185	P186	P187	P188	P189	P190	P191	P192
5. Open to a wildcard	P193	P194	P195	P196	P197	P198	P199	P200

Local position = $8 \times (\text{row} - 1) + \text{emblem}$. Wrap modified position to 1-40. Global case = $40 \times (\text{department} - 1) + \text{local position}$.

The Listening Fee Nobody Agreed To

I opened the Office of People Who Have Something to Tell You with a gold microphone, six upholstered chairs, and a sign that said I UNDERSTAND. The sign cost more than the chairs. That was deliberate. A chair supports one person. My understanding was intended to support an entire market.

Shawna arrived carrying the enormous game binder against her hip. The spine had developed the soft, defeated curve of a man asked to attend another meeting. She set it on the table. One chair rose half an inch. Tank caught the coffee before my administration could baptize its own documents.

“Why is there a microphone?” Shawna asked.

“So nobody feels unheard.”

She touched the switch. My voice came out of a speaker in the bathroom.

“They hear you flushing,” Tank said.

I explained that this was a pilot arrangement. Mercedes explained that every arrangement I did not understand was apparently a pilot, and that I should stop allowing aircraft into the furniture budget. Rosa unplugged the speaker. Instantly the room became capable of conversation.

The proposal was simple. People in these games had jobs, friends, secrets, ambitions, terrible employers, and requests that did not fit into a yes-or-no box. We would listen. We would notice whose company felt interesting. We would find a story worth sitting inside. I had expanded that proposal into a department with a Director of Emotional Weather because a title that good should not have to wait for an actual vacancy.

Rosa read the first sheet. “You have charged a handling fee for feelings.”

“Fictional fee.”

“It has your bank details.”

“Fictional ambition.”

She drew one line through the amount and another through the account number. I admired her commitment to clarity even as she dismantled my retirement. Then she placed a bowl of oranges where the invoice tray had been. Everybody understood the new system immediately. You took an orange. You could talk. You could also remain completely quiet, an option my draft had neglected to monetize.

Mercedes sat in the chair facing the window. “Some of these stories are sad.”

“We have tissues.”

“That isn't a recommendation.”

She was right. A box of tissues did not make every story the right company for every evening. A game about grief might be welcome because it took grief seriously. On another evening the same game might feel like somebody delivering a piano through your chest. The reader got to decide. My stamp, though gold and offensively heavy, could not settle the matter.

Tank opened the binder at a page covered in resource bars. “This one wants me to manage food.”

“Narrative food.”

“I'm already managing real food. Rosa got the last orange.”

Here was the second distinction I had tried to bury beneath stationery: a game could wait for a decision and still make that decision feel pressured. A calendar, a dwindling supply, a political bargain, a friendship with consequences - none required quick fingers to produce a tight stomach. We needed to say what the demands actually were. We also needed to let a perfectly good game remain a perfectly good game that somebody did not want tonight.

Shawna moved my microphone to the end of the table. "And a lot of reading is still a lot of reading."

I put that on the board. Under it I wrote NO EXAM AFTERWARD. Tank added UNLESS AIDEN HAS LOST HIS KEYS AGAIN. The keys were in my pocket. I made a point of finding them silently.

The reader's chair was not at the end of the table beneath the seal. Rosa put it wherever the reader wanted. Mercedes turned the screen so other people could follow without leaning across whoever held the controls. We agreed that a shared story did not automatically become a multiplayer game. Sometimes one person clicked while the others offered theories. Sometimes everybody shut up so a line could land. Sometimes the best contribution was bringing water and not explaining the joke.

I tried the microphone again. Nothing happened. I checked the cord, the switch, the speaker, and the magnificent little green light. Shawna watched me conduct a full technical inquiry.

"It's unplugged," she said.

"I know."

"Then why keep talking into it?"

Because, privately, I had been hoping my position would supply electricity.

We opened the first page without amplification. The tiny red stapler rested beside the oranges. For once it was not holding together a policy. It was keeping the window from knocking shut.

P161 / PROMISING / pointer input / pace: unknown / native co-op: unknown

Coffee Talk

The Espresso Machine Requests a Confidentiality Agreement

Edition considered: PC first game

I installed a velvet rope around the coffee machine because the first game concerned intimate conversations, and intimacy deserved a premium entrance. Tank walked around the rope to reach the sugar. That exposed a structural weakness in my business model.

“You're supposed to tell me your problem first,” I said. “Then I prepare the appropriate drink.”

“My problem is a rope in front of the sugar.”

Shawna watched me remove it. On the screen, Coffee Talk offered a counter in an alternate Seattle where fantasy people had recognizable troubles. I immediately proposed separate departments for elves, orcs, and people who ordered something complicated. Rosa replaced all three signs with CUSTOMERS.

I brewed a cup of real coffee and began explaining how its bitterness represented the customer's journey. Mercedes tasted it. “It represents you forgetting the water.” She made another pot while I listened to a fictional conversation that managed, without a velvet rope, to be interesting. The office's first successful intervention was letting somebody else use the kitchen.

The actual attraction

Coffee Talk makes a café counter into a place to get to know recurring people. The fantasy setting puts a fresh surface on work, romance, identity, and belonging. Serving drinks influences story branches; the appeal is noticing a person's request and watching relationships develop.

The catch worth knowing

Use the main story with manual text advance; avoid timed Challenge mode. Expect substantial reading and ingredient selection. Drink choices can change story branches. Check the brewing interface and text controls; any decorative latte work is a separate hold/drag question.

An opening invitation

Choose the main Story mode and manual text advance. Serve one early request, then stay for the conversation it supports. Notice whether ingredients add pleasure or interrupt listening; check the exact edition's controls before settling in.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Admitted because the guests have interesting lives and my coffee machine has finally been demoted from therapist to appliance.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Steam supports the first game's premise and drink-driven story. The identified secondary walkthrough separates the main story from timed Challenge objectives; this is a mode-specific recommendation. Manual advance, brewing and hold comfort still need checking in the chosen edition. The whole-game pace field remains unknown.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/914800/>

Source 2: <https://www.trueachievements.com/game/Coffee-Talk/walkthrough>

P162 / CONDITIONAL / pointer input / pace: unknown / native co-op: unknown

Coffee Talk Episode 2: Hibiscus & Butterfly

The Second Cup Has Retained Counsel

Edition considered: PC sequel

When the café returned with hibiscus and butterfly pea, I announced a botanical expansion of the listening office. I put a fern behind reception. It had no duties, but its posture suggested excellent discretion.

“That’s plastic,” Rosa said.

“Then it won’t repeat anything.”

Tank arrived with two cups bearing identical elaborate swirls. I praised his mastery of latte art. He turned one over. It was a saucer. The artistic department had been operating at an angle.

The sequel’s customers already had lives before I entered the room. That offended my instinct to introduce everybody, but Mercedes insisted that catching up was a pleasure of returning. Shawna found me preparing an official welcome speech for a fictional barista who had done the job before.

She crossed out the speech and wrote LISTEN FIRST. I drew a heart in the margin. It looked like a dented radish. The plastic fern declined to comment, maintaining the strongest professional record of anybody I had hired that day.

The actual attraction

The second Coffee Talk offers more café conversations with returning and new fantasy customers, additional drink ingredients, and latte-art play. It suits an appetite for spending more time with this particular world rather than racing through a chain of dramatic reveals.

The catch worth knowing

Recipes and returning relationships can increase the things to remember. The official description includes fluid-simulation latte art, so drawing or held-pointer demands need checking separately. Nothing about the calm presentation establishes a complete absence of fiddly inputs.

An opening invitation

Make an early drink and follow one customer’s situation. Try the art interface only if it interests you; inspect how to proceed if it does not. Decide whether the return feels welcoming or depends too much on previous familiarity.

Aiden’s entirely unnecessary ruling

Approved for an evening when catching up with fictional regulars sounds better than hearing my new employee-orientation speech.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected public Steam primary description and category declarations for PC sequel. Premise and listed features are source-supported; control workload, memory and mood routing are editorial judgments, not completion testing. Absent co-op or timed-input declarations remain unknown.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1663220/>

P163 / CONDITIONAL / pointer input / pace: unknown / native co-op: unknown

VA-11 Hall-A: Cyberpunk Bartender Action

The Bartender Refuses My Corporate Mission Statement

Edition considered: PC release

I put on a silver jacket to demonstrate cyberpunk readiness. The jacket reflected the lamp into Tank's eyes. He rotated my chair until I faced the wall, which apparently solved both the lighting problem and the presentation.

"I'm building atmosphere," I said.

"You're building a second sun."

In VA-11 Hall-A, the bar's customers carried news of a corporate dystopia into conversations about ordinary life. I designed a cocktail called The Synergy. It contained five ingredients and no clear purpose. Mercedes asked whether it came with a mandatory team-building exercise.

Shawna took over the measuring while I tried to remember whose drink required what. It was a useful correction: running a fictional bar involved an interface and requests, not just leaning against a counter looking expensive. Rosa gave my jacket to the back of a chair. The chair immediately looked more employable. I stopped inventing drinks long enough to discover that the people ordering them were the interesting part.

The actual attraction

The game uses bartending to frame a series of conversations about life in a high-tech, unequal city. Drinks influence which stories unfold. Its attraction is the contrast between large political systems and the specific people living, working, joking, and struggling inside them.

The catch worth knowing

Reading, recipe selection, and remembering customer preferences are real parts of the experience. Sexual conversation, alcohol, and adult subject matter belong to its tone. Check ingredient operations and any mixing or waiting controls rather than inferring simplicity from the visual-novel label.

An opening invitation

Complete one customer order with the recipe information available on screen. Then judge the conversation itself: are these people enjoyable company, and is the bar routine a satisfying rhythm rather than unwanted clerical work?

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Licensed to serve intrigue, provided nobody mistakes my metallic jacket for a required peripheral or a source of useful illumination.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected public Steam primary description and category declarations for PC release. Premise and listed features are source-supported; control workload, memory and mood routing are editorial judgments, not completion testing. Absent co-op or timed-input declarations remain unknown.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/447530/>

P164 / **CONDITIONAL** / mixed input / pace: unknown / native co-op: unknown

The Red Strings Club

The Pottery Wheel Knows Too Much

Edition considered: PC release

I welcomed the pottery wheel as evidence that corporate espionage had finally developed a respectable arts budget. Tank asked whether I knew how to use it. I assured him that my hands understood luxury.

The clay collapsed immediately.

“Your hands have issued a correction,” Shawna said.

The Red Strings Club combines conversations with bartending, shaping implants, and impersonating voices. I had assumed a game about talking would permit me to delegate all physical technique to my charisma. The little ruined bowl in front of me suggested otherwise.

Mercedes examined my attempt. “What is it?”

“A vessel for difficult questions.”

“It has no bottom.”

Rosa set a plate beneath it. We discussed whether happiness imposed by a corporation sounded like a service or a threat, while my vessel leaked onto a napkin. For once my failure had produced a relevant metaphor. I attempted to claim that this had been intentional. The entire room declined, politely but with excellent coordination.

The actual attraction

This cyberpunk conspiracy story asks what happiness and emotional freedom mean. Its unusual sequence of bartending, implant pottery, and phone impersonation gives those arguments different forms; you manipulate both objects and conversations while learning what a corporation intends.

The catch worth knowing

The store explicitly describes a lathe and cocktail manipulation, which makes pointer precision and held movement significant checks. This is not safely described as dialogue-only. Its emotional manipulation and corporate-control themes may also feel sharper than a relaxed conversation game.

An opening invitation

Inspect the first hands-on task as soon as it appears. Determine whether its movement is enjoyable and whether the offered controls work for you. A compelling ethical question is not an obligation to tolerate an irritating interface.

Aiden’s entirely unnecessary ruling

Provisionally admitted because my bottomless bowl has demonstrated why every philosophy department needs a practical spill tray.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected public Steam primary description and category declarations for PC release. Premise and listed features are source-supported; control workload, memory and mood routing are editorial judgments, not completion testing. Absent co-op or timed-input declarations remain unknown.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/589780/>

P165 / CONDITIONAL / pointer input / pace: unknown / native co-op: unknown

Neo Cab

Five Stars for Not Explaining the City

Edition considered: PC release

I appointed myself the office's mobility visionary and sat in a parked car wearing driving gloves. Shawna held the keys outside my window. Apparently the position did not include access to the fleet.

Neo Cab's Lina makes a living transporting people through an automated city while searching for a missing friend. I prepared a passenger questionnaire with a section called OPINIONS ABOUT YOUR EXCEPTIONAL DRIVER. Mercedes used it to shade her eyes.

"What does the passenger want?" she asked.

"Transportation."

"Try starting there."

Tank got in and requested the kitchen. I delivered an unnecessary speech about the future of cities. He got out, walked six steps, and arrived before my conclusion. Rosa awarded him five stars.

The game put conversations, income, and emotional state into the same working life. That was more interesting than my imaginary steering credentials. I took off the gloves and read the next exchange. Shawna left the keys where they were.

The actual attraction

Neo Cab is a visual novel about Lina, a human driver in an increasingly automated city. Passengers become sources of stories and possible leads in her search. Her emotional state affects available responses, giving conversations a connection to the strain of working and surviving.

The catch worth knowing

Do not confuse its driving premise with a promise about vehicle controls: the inspected listing calls it a visual novel and declares a mouse-only option. Money, ratings, and emotion restrictions can still create pressure. Check reading flow and map/menu operations.

An opening invitation

Follow an early passenger conversation through to its outcome. Look at how a mood change affects the next available response. Decide whether that constraint deepens the character or makes the conversation feel less enjoyable.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Receives a route permit because the passengers have more to say than my glove-based transportation strategy.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected public Steam primary description and category declarations for PC release. Premise and listed features are source-supported; control workload, memory and mood routing are editorial judgments, not completion testing. Absent co-op or timed-input declarations remain unknown.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/794540/>

P166 / CONDITIONAL / pointer input / pace: unknown / native co-op: unknown

Eliza

The Microphone Has Been Replaced by a Script

Edition considered: PC release

I hired myself as the human face of an automated listening service. The face was excellent. The service consisted of Shawna passing me cards from behind a screen.

“Please describe the issue,” I read.

Tank pointed at the screen. “You’re behind a curtain in the dining room.”

The next card said ACKNOWLEDGE CONCERN. I acknowledged it in a voice I believed sounded professionally upholstered. Mercedes pulled the curtain aside. There was Shawna, the cards, and my invoice printer. The entire technological revolution fit on a folding table.

Eliza asks what happens when a human worker delivers words supplied by a counseling system. Rosa made clear that our game discussion was about a fictional workplace and its questions, not a service anybody here was receiving. I nodded and put the cards down.

Without the script, I had to decide what I actually thought. It took longer. The answer was less polished. For the first time that afternoon, it also belonged to me.

The actual attraction

Eliza follows Evelyn as she works as a human proxy for an AI counseling program and reconnects with people from her past. Fully voiced characters and a contemporary setting carry questions about work, responsibility, technical power, and whether simulated care meets real needs.

The catch worth knowing

The subject includes personal distress and the limits of counseling technology. Consider whether that is welcome material tonight. Expect substantial dialogue and choices; verify text pacing and navigation. This is a fictional story, not an instruction manual for supporting another person.

An opening invitation

Read an early work scene and a conversation outside it. Compare the constrained professional role with Evelyn’s own voice. Continue if the contrast makes you curious, rather than because the subject seems worthy enough to require homework.

Aiden’s entirely unnecessary ruling

Granted a hearing after my automated empathy platform was revealed to be Shawna with index cards and better judgment.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected public Steam primary description and category declarations for PC release. Premise and listed features are source-supported; control workload, memory and mood routing are editorial judgments, not completion testing. Absent co-op or timed-input declarations remain unknown.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/716500/>

P167 / CONDITIONAL / pointer input / pace: waits / native co-op: unknown

Citizen Sleeper

The Dice Have Unionized

Edition considered: PC first game

I rolled six dice across the table to allocate the afternoon's work. Every result assigned the unpleasant tasks to Tank. He inspected the sheet, then the dice, then me.

"Why does every number mean Tank?"

"Elegant interface."

Shawna rewrote the allocation table while Rosa moved the snacks out of the resource pool. In Citizen Sleeper, dice and cycles shape the life of someone escaping corporate ownership on a space station. I found its distinction between available actions and endless demands uncomfortably relevant to my staffing policy.

Mercedes gave me one die and the printer manual. "Use your opportunity."

The page I needed was underneath the binder. I spent my turn moving it. Tank spent his making tea. His choice immediately improved the station.

The game would wait for an input; that did not make its scarcity disappear. We could think carefully and still feel the pull between a useful job and a person worth helping. My dice system had finally encountered a consequence it could not assign elsewhere.

The actual attraction

Citizen Sleeper turns life on a crowded station into choices about work, friendships, resources, and survival. Assigning dice creates a clear connection between what you can do this cycle and what you care about. Its characters make those allocations feel personal rather than merely numerical.

The catch worth knowing

Steam declares playable without timed input, but the story uses resource pressure and advancing clocks. Several systems and ongoing relationships need attention. That declaration does not verify hold-free controls; inspect dice placement, text size, and the station interface.

An opening invitation

Spend one cycle slowly, explaining to yourself what each chosen action will cost or advance. Meet somebody whose situation interests you. Notice whether the limited opportunities feel engaging or like a second schedule to manage.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Approved when you want meaningful tradeoffs and can tolerate the dice refusing to fund my entire executive department.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected public Steam primary description and category declarations for PC first game. Premise and listed features are source-supported; control workload, memory and mood routing are editorial judgments, not completion testing. Absent co-op or timed-input declarations remain unknown.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1578650/>

P168 / CONDITIONAL / pointer input / pace: waits / native co-op: unknown

Citizen Sleeper 2: Starward Vector

The Escape Ship Has a Procurement Committee

Edition considered: PC sequel

I unveiled our escape ship using a cardboard box, a kitchen timer, and three chairs. Tank asked what we were escaping. I gestured toward the commission's paperwork.

"You made the paperwork."

"Then I understand the threat."

Citizen Sleeper 2 moves between habitats with a ship, crew, and risky contracts. I appointed Mercedes navigator without asking whether she wanted the role. She navigated directly out of my cardboard vessel. Rosa followed with the snacks. The crew's first joint decision was excellent.

Shawna stayed long enough to examine my maintenance budget. I had spent most of it on a gold captain's plate. She set it beneath a wobbling chair, turning decorative authority into a functioning repair.

Contracts in the game would require preparation and decisions about stress and resources. My fictional command had already illustrated why choosing companions involved more than collecting names. I asked the others whether they wanted to return. They did, on the condition that I stop referring to the living room as deep space.

The actual attraction

The sequel expands the dice-driven roleplaying into travel, crew-building, and contracts across an asteroid belt. A battered ship can become a home, while temporary jobs bring distinct characters and risks. The appeal is making a future through relationships as well as careful decisions.

The catch worth knowing

The current Steam record declares adjustable difficulty and play without timed input. It also describes stress, damaged dice, and multi-cycle contracts: waiting for you is not the same as removing consequences. Inspect the actual difficulty choices before relying on them.

An opening invitation

Learn one contract's objective, available dice, and stress consequences before committing actions. Try a manageable early job and ask whether preparing with a crew adds pleasure or too many interconnected things to track.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Commissioned after the captain's nameplate proved better at supporting a chair than supporting my claim to leadership.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected public Steam primary description and category declarations for PC sequel. Premise and listed features are source-supported; control workload, memory and mood routing are editorial judgments, not completion testing. Absent co-op or timed-input declarations remain unknown.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/2442460/>

P169 / CONDITIONAL / pointer input / pace: unknown / native co-op: unknown

Disco Elysium - The Final Cut

My Necktie Has Requested a Separate Office

Edition considered: PC Final Cut

I arrived in a spectacular tie and announced that the office required a detective. Tank asked what I had lost. I said that true investigation began before the crime. He checked whether I still had the receipt for the tie.

Disco Elysium filled a detective's head with competing perspectives. This struck me as efficient staffing. I already possessed confidence, ambition, and an inner voice insisting that expensive stationery would solve things. Shawna pointed out that none of them could locate the printer's power button.

Mercedes offered to voice my common sense. I objected that the role was already occupied. She waited. The silence established a vacancy.

Rosa studied the tie. "That thing's going to give advice, isn't it?"

In the game, the comedy and damage sit close together; a magnificent declaration can conceal a person in real trouble. I loosened my own tie before reading further. It had begun to feel like an unusually ornate argument I did not need to win.

The actual attraction

The Final Cut presents a dense, voiced detective roleplaying story about a damaged investigator and a politically complicated city. Skills become argumentative inner voices, making character-building part of the writing. Conversations can be funny, cruel, revealing, and unexpectedly tender.

The catch worth knowing

Expect extensive dialogue, skill checks, inventory and character menus, and mature material including addiction and violence. A failed choice can have consequences. The manually checked source confirms the Final Cut edition, but does not certify all interactions as untimed or hold-free.

An opening invitation

Follow an early conversation and inspect one relevant skill explanation. Decide whether the competing voices delight you or interrupt the person you want to hear. Treat the opening as a test of tone as much as controls.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Admitted only after my tie's application for municipal funding was rejected on the grounds that it already consumed enough resources.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Manually inspected Steam app632470 on 2026-09-20, exact title Disco Elysium - The Final Cut. Source supports full English voice acting, skills, roleplaying choices, and mature content. Control and workload judgments remain editorial.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/632470/>

P170 / **CONDITIONAL** / pointer input / pace: mixed / native co-op: unknown

NORCO

The Refinery Declines My Mood Board

Edition considered: PC release

I prepared a tasteful mood board for the industrial South. It contained a swamp photograph, a neon swatch, and a note reading ADD ATMOSPHERE. Mercedes looked at it for several seconds.

“Where are the people?”

I had left room in the lower corner, which did not improve my answer.

NORCO's world contains refineries, shops, family memories, strange technology, and people whose lives do not fit inside an aesthetic label. Shawna replaced my mood board with a map of who was missing and why the search mattered. Suddenly we had a reason to go somewhere.

Tank offered a stuffed monkey as our departmental mascot. I tried to give it a security clearance. Rosa took the badge away before I could pierce the fabric. The monkey's refusal to participate made it our most plausible investigator.

We followed the first thread of the story. My atmospheric swatches remained unused. Outside the window, a delivery truck backed up with an ugly practical beep. For once I let a place make its own sound.

The actual attraction

NORCO combines a missing-person search with family history, industrial landscapes, and increasingly strange science fiction in South Louisiana. Its dialogue-focused point-and-click structure invites attention to both particular characters and the forces shaping their world.

The catch worth knowing

The official description also mentions puzzles and fights; do not treat dialogue-focused as proof that every sequence is mechanically quiet. Expect dense imagery, unfamiliar connections, and bereavement. Check each new interaction type and the text/interface size.

An opening invitation

Explore an early location and follow one clue about the missing brother. Pause to decide whether the place feels intriguing in its own right. Inspect the first unfamiliar mechanical sequence before assuming later play matches the opening.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Receives a travel warrant because an industrial landscape deserves more attention than my decorative label reading interesting decay.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected public Steam primary description and category declarations for PC release. Premise and listed features are source-supported; control workload, memory and mood routing are editorial judgments, not completion testing. Absent co-op or timed-input declarations remain unknown.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1221250/>

The Committee for Leaving a Sentence Alone

By the middle of the afternoon, I had developed a method for responding to every fictional confession. I leaned forward, lowered my voice, and said, "That must be difficult." It worked beautifully until Tank told me the printer was out of paper.

"That must be difficult," I said.

"It must be loaded."

Mercedes slid a sheet toward me. She had kept a record of my contributions. The same six words appeared seventeen times. At the bottom she had drawn my microphone inside a recycling bin. The drawing was very good. I considered commissioning a portrait before I understood the insult.

"Listening isn't waiting to deploy your sentence," she said.

I wanted to object on professional grounds. Unfortunately the profession was one I had invented that morning, and its entire training consisted of buying the sign. Shawna took the page and folded it into a small stand for the screen. My empty reassurance was finally providing practical support.

We had reached the games where choices mattered in different ways. Some changed a line. Some spent a resource. Some opened or closed a route. Some simply let you express how a character regarded a thing that would happen anyway. None of these automatically made the others dishonest. The pleasure could be in steering events, in inhabiting a voice, or in noticing a detail that another person missed.

I proposed a universal significance scale. Rosa asked whether I could accurately scale the amount of tea left in my cup. I lifted it to demonstrate. It was empty. She refilled it without comment, which was both kind and a devastating audit.

Tank had found a conversation he wanted to finish. The rest of us were halfway through a discussion of what he should say. He raised one hand.

"Can I hear what they say first?"

We could. We did. The room became quieter than my expensive acoustic panels had ever managed to make it. A fictional person finished a thought. Tank chose a response none of us had suggested. It belonged to his reading of the scene, and nobody needed to win an argument about it.

That gave Shawna the policy she had wanted all day: suggestions by invitation. A companion could read aloud if asked. A companion could keep a note if wanted. A companion could solve a menu problem without taking over the character's life. If a difficult choice was part of the fun, we did not steal it in the name of being helpful.

I approved the policy with the gold stamp. The ink pad was dry.

"You can just say yes," Rosa said.

I said yes. It left no embossed border, no seal, no glorious mark that future historians could place beneath glass. Everybody understood me anyway.

Outside the window, the wind changed. The red stapler held. My Director of Emotional Weather had produced less useful weather management than a stationery item with one visible screw.

P171 / CONDITIONAL / pointer input / pace: unknown / native co-op: unknown

Kentucky Route Zero

The Delivery Address Is Underneath the Road

Edition considered: PC complete five-act edition

I took charge of route planning with a map so large that Tank had to stand outside the room to unfold it. Our destination was a secret highway beneath Kentucky. I drew a confident arrow through the middle of the table.

“That’s not a road,” Shawna said.

“It’s a conceptual route.”

“It’s the sandwich grease.”

Kentucky Route Zero seemed less interested in rewarding my navigation credentials than in the people met along the way. A delivery, a debt, a conversation: ordinary things could open into rooms that felt like theater or a dream. Mercedes asked me to stop demanding that every strange image produce an immediate explanation.

I folded the map. It resisted. Tank folded me out of the way and dealt with it properly. Rosa left a small lamp on the table. We read the next scene without trying to turn it into a checklist. The grease mark remained where it was, giving our official route map its only reliable local landmark.

The actual attraction

This five-act magical-realist adventure follows a delivery into a world of strange roads, precarious work, debts, and fragile communities. Its pleasure lies in language, staging, music, and atmosphere. Choices can feel like shaping a performance rather than selecting the correct solution to a puzzle.

The catch worth knowing

Expect substantial reading, ambiguity, and a pace that may feel deliberately indirect. The PC Edition has been manually matched to the assigned complete game. Check movement and text advance; no inspected source establishes every scene as free of held or timed input.

An opening invitation

Stay with one early encounter rather than trying to solve the whole world’s meaning. Notice whether choosing a line makes you feel involved. If the theatrical distance leaves you cold, that is useful taste information, not a reading failure.

Aiden’s entirely unnecessary ruling

Granted an underground delivery permit because the address is interesting enough to survive my inability to fold its map.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Manually inspected Steam app231200, Kentucky Route Zero: PC Edition; the five-act PC edition matches this assigned game despite title-review flag. Other control and mood judgments remain provisional.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/231200/>

P172 / **CONDITIONAL** / directional input / pace: mixed / native co-op: unknown

Night in the Woods

The Reunion Committee Has Been Banned from the Roof

Edition considered: PC release

I planned a homecoming party for myself even though I had only gone to the shop. Tank was instructed to say that I had changed. He said I had forgotten the milk.

“Emotionally changed.”

“Still no milk.”

Night in the Woods returns Mae to a town and friendships that have continued without her. I understood the desire to pick up an old role. I was less enthusiastic about the possibility that other people had developed their own opinions while I was away.

Mercedes took the welcome banner down from the doorway. “It has been nine minutes.”

Shawna pointed out that a story about hanging out could still ask us to move and jump through its town. I had been ready to approve it on the strength of autumn leaves alone. Rosa asked whether my leaf-based assessment included the roof I was now suggesting Tank climb to hang the banner. It did not. We left the banner at chair height and paid attention to the actual controls.

The actual attraction

Night in the Woods offers the company of young adults negotiating friendship, disappointment, work, and changes in their hometown. Its animal characters carry recognizably human conversations, with a mystery growing around the edges of daily wandering.

The catch worth knowing

Movement and platforming are part of its adventure structure, and additional activity types require checking. Do not file it as a static visual novel. Its themes can be bleak, including economic decline and emotional distress, despite the bright designs and frequent jokes.

An opening invitation

Walk through an early stretch of town and talk to somebody who knows Mae. Test the movement before investing in the story. Decide whether the everyday conversations are reward enough for the amount of traversal between them.

Aiden’s entirely unnecessary ruling

Conditionally welcomed because a reunion should reveal how people changed, not just congratulate me for returning with the wrong groceries.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected Steam primary description/category declarations for PC release. Premise and explicit features are supported; input workload and preference routing are editorial judgments. No full-playthrough, no-hold, or universal no-timer certification.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/481510/>

P173 / PROMISING / directional input / pace: waits / native co-op: unknown

Beacon Pines

One Word Has Overturned the Entire Department

Edition considered: PC release

I wrote a ceremonial sentence for the office: AIDEN WAS WISE. Mercedes replaced the last word with AVAILABLE. Tank replaced it with LATE. Rosa said both amendments could stand.

Beacon Pines makes words into objects that can alter a story's turning points. This was a dangerous precedent for a man who had invested heavily in controlling the minutes. I tried locking the marker in a drawer. Shawna opened it with the handle.

"Security needs work," she said.

The book's inviting appearance did not mean every possible branch would be comforting. That interested Mercedes, who liked the friction between a charming surface and something wrong beneath it. I liked the possibility of revisiting a decision until somebody called me wise.

Tank collected the three word cards and arranged them into AIDEN WAS AVAILABLE LATE. It was both a correction and a workable office schedule. We let the fictional story keep its own surprises while my real sentence remained, at last, supported by evidence.

The actual attraction

Beacon Pines combines exploring a small town with collecting word charms and revisiting branches through a story tree. New words can transform a moment and open different events. Curiosity about how a sentence changes the world becomes part of solving its mystery.

The catch worth knowing

The Steam record declares play without timed input and keyboard-only operation. Branch tracking still adds a memory burden, and the cute art accompanies creepy events. Those declarations do not establish that every control avoids holds; test ordinary walking and menu selection.

An opening invitation

Collect an early charm and use it at a turning point. Then inspect how the story tree represents the route. Continue if comparing possibilities feels like discovery rather than keeping several unfinished stories in your head.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Approved because the Department of One Carefully Chosen Word has achieved more reform than my complete annual report.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected Steam primary description/category declarations for PC release. Premise and explicit features are supported; input workload and preference routing are editorial judgments. No full-playthrough, no-hold, or universal no-timer certification.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1269640/>

P174 / PROMISING / pointer input / pace: waits / native co-op: unknown

Mutazione

The Garden Has Heard About My Promotion

Edition considered: PC release

I entered the community garden with a badge reading DIRECTOR OF GROWTH. Rosa asked which plant I had grown. I pointed at the plastic fern. She removed my badge without disturbing its leaves.

Mutazione's gardens and conversations offered a different kind of attention: visit, listen, learn how people were connected, and let a place become familiar. I began a gossip chart with myself in the center. Mercedes turned the paper over.

"You aren't in this town."

"I could be a visiting dignitary."

"You could be quiet for one conversation."

Shawna listened to the musical garden while Tank arranged our actual plants so they could reach the window. One plant leaned away from my badge. I declined to interpret that as a performance review.

The story's community had secrets and pain as well as warmth. It did not need me to certify it wholesome. I sat down, asked Rosa what the real plant needed, and received the remarkably actionable answer: water, occasionally, without a speech.

The actual attraction

Mutazione follows Kai visiting her grandfather in an unusual island community. Conversations, old tensions, and musical gardens sit alongside the supernatural plot. Its attraction is spending enough time with a place that the relationships begin to matter.

The catch worth knowing

Illness, family secrets, and community conflict are central; gentle presentation is not a promise of emotionally light material. Steam declares no timed input, mouse-only and keyboard-only options, and save-anytime. Verify those options on the installed version and inspect ordinary navigation.

An opening invitation

Meet one resident and spend time with an early garden interaction. Judge the balance between conversation and moving through the community. If you like it, a note of the next person to visit may make returning easier.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Admitted because the garden's useful advice was shorter than my title and considerably more likely to keep something alive.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected Steam primary description/category declarations for PC release. Premise and explicit features are supported; input workload and preference routing are editorial judgments. No full-playthrough, no-hold, or universal no-timer certification.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1080750/>

P175 / **CONDITIONAL** / directional input / pace: mixed / native co-op: unknown

Wytchwood

The Witch Has Rejected My Ingredient Spreadsheet

Edition considered: PC release

I proposed a centralized inventory for the witch's cupboard. Everything received an impressive label. The first jar said PREMIUM BOTANICAL SOLUTION. Rosa opened it.

“Dried basil.”

“Branding.”

Wytchwood's old witch gathered peculiar materials and used them to intervene in other people's stories. I admired her confidence until Shawna pointed out that confidence did not collect the ingredients. Somebody still had to go find what the recipe required.

Tank handed me a shopping list. I returned with a notebook, two gold clips, and nothing on it. Mercedes suggested I might be the cautionary character whose moral the witch was preparing to teach.

I defended my procurement philosophy. Rosa defended dinner by sending Tank. On screen, a chain of ingredients led toward a particular spell. I finally understood the actual attraction: making a strange recipe come together. I also understood the possible burden, because my own cupboard still contained seven labelled jars whose contents I could not remember.

The actual attraction

Wytchwood turns gothic fairy-tale errands into gathering and crafting. The witch's judgments give the recipes personality: ingredients are steps toward changing a troublesome situation, not simply collecting for its own sake. The illustrated world helps make each place distinctive.

The catch worth knowing

Expect repeated travel, nested recipes, and remembering where resources come from. The official description includes monsters and overcoming them through tools and spells; do not assume that crafting removes all hazards or movement demands. Check inventory and held movement.

An opening invitation

Follow one early recipe from request to ingredients to use. Notice whether retracing a route is satisfying familiarity or unwanted repetition. The useful trial is the whole small crafting loop, not just admiring the art.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Granted cupboard access provided the inventory lists actual ingredients rather than my premium names for forgotten herbs.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected Steam primary description/category declarations for PC release. Premise and explicit features are supported; input workload and preference routing are editorial judgments. No full-playthrough, no-hold, or universal no-timer certification.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/729000/>

P176 / DETOUR / mixed input / pace: real time / native co-op: unknown

Wandersong

The Bard Has Been Asked to Lower the Volume of Leadership

Edition considered: PC release

I declared myself a walking musical instrument. Mercedes said that explained several complaints. Tank asked whether I came with a volume knob. I said artistic expression could not be reduced to hardware.

Shawna closed the window.

Wandersong's bard uses singing to interact with a world full of people and puzzles. That sounded like a strong argument for my continued solos until Rosa noticed the word platforming in the description. I had skipped it because it was standing between musical and adventure.

We tested a simple musical idea at the table. I sang a grand note. Tank moved the orange bowl six inches. I sang another. He moved it back. The system was responsive, but I could not establish what I had achieved.

Mercedes showed me how a response could be a conversation rather than applause. The bard's journey might offer that pleasure, but our invitation still had to account for the movement. I wrote down the catch and, for a historic moment, did it without singing.

The actual attraction

Wandersong builds a characterful adventure around a bard who changes things through music. Its humor, unusual interactions, and emotional story can make singing feel like a way of meeting the world. The official pitch also explicitly calls it a platforming adventure.

The catch worth knowing

Directional movement, platforming, and selecting musical responses are meaningful demands. The developer's broad accessibility language about color and sound does not answer every motor-input question. This is a contrasting option for someone who wants those active elements, not a guaranteed quiet story.

An opening invitation

Try an early singing interaction and a small piece of traversal. Check whether choosing the notes and moving through the space are enjoyable. If either feels like an obstacle, keep the musical premise separate from the actual fit.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Invited as a musical detour after the commission confirmed that enjoying a bard does not require enduring my full operatic briefing.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected Steam primary description/category declarations for PC release. Premise and explicit features are supported; input workload and preference routing are editorial judgments. No full-playthrough, no-hold, or universal no-timer certification.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/530320/>

P177 / **CONDITIONAL** / mixed input / pace: mixed / native co-op: yes

Chicory: A Colorful Tale

The Brush Has More Authority Than the Director

Edition considered: PC release

I took responsibility for restoring color to the office. The first thing I painted was my nameplate. The second was the sleeve of Tank's shirt. He asked whether this counted as environmental storytelling.

Chicory put a powerful brush into the hands of someone following a celebrated artist. I announced that I understood the pressure of artistic greatness. Mercedes asked me to distinguish pressure from the lid I had not opened on the paint.

Shawna placed clean paper in front of me. "Make something."

I spent several minutes deciding what would be worthy of the office. Rosa drew a little orange with legs and laughed. Her orange had already achieved the evening's purpose.

The game could be enjoyed through painting, exploration, and its characters, but a brush meant actual input: pointing, moving, perhaps holding. Two people could paint together locally, which was a real feature and not merely me assigning Tank to clean up. We read that distinction aloud before my administrative imagination found a loophole.

The actual attraction

Chicory is a coloring-book adventure about taking up an artist's brush. Painting changes the environment and supports puzzles, while the story explores creativity and the people around it. The official listing explicitly includes local cooperative painting.

The catch worth knowing

Painting, directional movement, and more active sequences need separate checks. Local co-op does not necessarily give both people identical roles. Inspect brush behavior and the game's actual options before deciding whether the action is welcome; no assumed setting is required by this card.

An opening invitation

Color one small area and use paint for an early puzzle. If playing together, establish who controls movement and who paints. The point is to discover whether making marks feels playful without turning the result into an art assessment.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Authorized because Rosa's walking orange accomplished more joy than my perfect, unfinished plan for the entire color spectrum.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected Steam primary description/category declarations for PC release. Premise and explicit features are supported; input workload and preference routing are editorial judgments. No full-playthrough, no-hold, or universal no-timer certification.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1123450/>

P178 / **CONDITIONAL** / directional input / pace: unknown / native co-op: unknown

Rakuen

The Storybook Has Refused My Fast-Track Stamp

Edition considered: PC release

I placed a ribbon across the storybook to celebrate our expedition. Rosa removed it before anybody had to untie something just to read. I called it an opening ceremony. She called it an obstacle.

Rakuen moves between a hospital and a fantasy world through a boy and his mother. Its people had unfinished business that would not become simpler because I had arrived with a gold stamp. I put the stamp away before Shawna had to ask.

Tank set a music box on the table. The tune stopped halfway through. I reached for it with an immediate repair proposal. Mercedes asked whether we could listen to the silence before deciding what it meant.

We did. Then Tank wound it again. It played on.

The game promised a non-combat adventure, which answered one useful question but not every question about puzzles or movement. Its emotional material deserved an equally clear introduction. I replaced the expedition ribbon with a bookmark. It would hold a place without insisting that anybody hurry beyond it.

The actual attraction

Rakuen follows a boy and his mother as helping people in a fantasy world reveals the lives of people around him. Music and character stories connect the two settings. The developer explicitly describes a non-combat adventure with puzzles and dialogue-based mysteries.

The catch worth knowing

Hospital life, illness, grief, and unfinished relationships are central themes. Non-combat does not mean no navigation or difficult puzzle. Check walking, object interaction, text advance, and any eerie sections; decide separately whether the emotional subject is welcome.

An opening invitation

Explore a small early area and speak with one person. Test the ordinary movement and the way information is presented. Continue for interest in the people, with permission to stop before an emotional scene feels like an obligation.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Receives a bookmark instead of a clearance stamp, because a story about other people's lives deserves room to set its own weight.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected Steam primary description/category declarations for PC release. Premise and explicit features are supported; input workload and preference routing are editorial judgments. No full-playthrough, no-hold, or universal no-timer certification.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/559210/>

P179 / **CONDITIONAL** / directional input / pace: unknown / native co-op: unknown

To the Moon

The Moon Has Not Approved My Itinerary

Edition considered: PC original release

I prepared a lunar travel package with a window seat and an unnecessarily formal boarding announcement. Tank asked how we would get there. I pointed at the illustration of a rocket. He said the illustration had no fuel.

To the Moon approaches its destination through a man's memories and a final wish. Shawna folded my itinerary in half. "Maybe listen to why he wants to go."

I had written the destination in enormous letters and left the reasons section blank. That was not an excellent document for this particular story.

Mercedes placed a small paper moon against the lamp. It cast a crooked shadow. Rosa left it crooked. We let the game reveal its connections in its own order rather than demanding a tidy account at the start.

I had intended to narrate the journey as an expedition. Instead I found myself paying attention to small objects and conversations. The moon stayed on the table. It was doing better work as a question than my whole travel department had done as an answer.

The actual attraction

To the Moon follows two doctors working backward through a dying man's memories to understand and fulfill his final wish. Its compact story links small details across a life. Music and changing context supply much of the emotional effect.

The catch worth knowing

The developer describes a non-combat experience, but movement, searching for objects, and puzzle interfaces remain. Bereavement and questions about memory and relationships carry significant emotional weight. Verify text advance and the particular PC version rather than assuming all ports behave alike.

An opening invitation

Play through an early memory investigation, noticing whether gathering its clues supports your curiosity. There is no need to solve the eventual meaning in advance. Check whether the dialogue rhythm and movement let the story land comfortably.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Permitted to approach the moon only after my itinerary acquired the essential missing field: why this journey matters to this person.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected Steam primary description/category declarations for PC original release. Premise and explicit features are supported; input workload and preference routing are editorial judgments. No full-playthrough, no-hold, or universal no-timer certification.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/206440/>

P180 / **CONDITIONAL** / directional input / pace: unknown / native co-op: unknown

Finding Paradise

The Contradictory Wish Has a Perfectly Valid Signature

Edition considered: PC release

I established a department for requests that could not both be true. Its first customer was me. I wanted the largest office and an intimate atmosphere; universal acclaim and complete privacy; help with the binder and sole credit for carrying it.

Shawna opened a fresh folder. “We may need more shelves.”

Finding Paradise follows a life and a wish that resist a simple summary. I proposed resolving the contradiction by choosing whichever half sounded more prestigious. Mercedes asked whether that would help the person whose life it was.

It would not.

Tank brought two chairs rather than the single enormous chair I had ordered. One faced the window. The other faced the room. Rosa said a person could want different things at different times without becoming an administrative error.

I placed my contradiction stamp face down. We listened to the story. The office had not solved human complexity, but it had finally stopped treating complexity as evidence that somebody had filled out the form incorrectly.

The actual attraction

Finding Paradise is a standalone follow-up in the memory-traversing series. The doctors investigate Colin's life and a wish whose apparent contradictions invite a closer look. It offers another character-centered story about how a life can mean more than its neatest explanation.

The catch worth knowing

Expect reading, walking, and attention to details that gain significance later. End-of-life material remains central. The publisher says previous games are not required, but that does not establish identical controls or a complete absence of unusual sequences.

An opening invitation

Follow the first substantial memory scene and identify one question you want answered. Check ordinary movement and dialogue handling. Let the uncertainty be part of the pleasure rather than trying to create a complete timeline immediately.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Filed under requests worth hearing twice, after my office admitted that a person is entitled to be more complicated than a checkbox.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected Steam primary description/category declarations for PC release. Premise and explicit features are supported; input workload and preference routing are editorial judgments. No full-playthrough, no-hold, or universal no-timer certification.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/337340/>

P181 / **CONDITIONAL** / directional input / pace: unknown / native co-op: unknown

Impostor Factory

The Bathroom Has Been Granted Temporal Jurisdiction

Edition considered: PC release

I refused to hold the next meeting anywhere without adequate facilities. Then Impostor Factory introduced a mansion party with a bathroom time machine, and I realized my facilities checklist had been embarrassingly provincial.

Tank inspected our bathroom. “We’ve got hot water.”

“For now. Think bigger.”

Shawna removed the label TEMPORAL OPERATIONS from the toilet before a guest could misunderstand it. Mercedes wanted to know why every impressive fictional building encouraged me to renovate a room that already worked.

The game's murder mystery and absurdity promised a story willing to change its own apparent shape. I prepared a timeline on the wall. Rosa asked me not to reveal anything merely to make the chart look complete. That was fair. A surprising story deserved to remain surprising.

Tank returned from the bathroom carrying the missing printer cable. “Recovered from the past,” he said. I accepted the joke as an official field report, which was the most useful temporal research our office conducted all evening.

The actual attraction

Impostor Factory begins with a strange party and a time-loop murder mystery, then develops into a broader narrative. Its mixture of absurd comedy and emotional storytelling makes it a candidate for someone who enjoys being led somewhere they did not initially expect.

The catch worth knowing

The publisher permits independent play but notes that series order affects the experience. Expect reading, walking, deaths, and disturbing imagery within the mystery. The time-loop premise does not itself verify the absence of timed tasks or unfamiliar input sequences.

An opening invitation

Follow the opening invitation and inspect an early area without looking up the eventual explanation. Check movement and dialogue handling. Decide whether the strange humor earns your trust before committing to the story's later changes of direction.

Aiden’s entirely unnecessary ruling

Admitted because a bathroom time machine is the first facilities upgrade capable of retrieving the meeting I wish I had cancelled.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected Steam primary description/category declarations for PC release. Premise and explicit features are supported; practical workload and routing are editorial judgments. No full-path input verification.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1182620/>

P182 / **CONDITIONAL** / directional input / pace: unknown / native co-op: unknown

A Bird Story

The Bird Declines to Complete the Questionnaire

Edition considered: PC release

I created a welcome form for an injured bird. It requested a name, a forwarding address, and an explanation of long-term goals. Rosa took the form away before I could invent a signature requirement.

A Bird Story tells its small tale without dialogue. This left my office's magnificent microphone with nothing to do. Tank suggested putting it in a cupboard. I suggested that silence could be amplified. Mercedes asked me to demonstrate without speaking.

I failed immediately.

Shawna placed a small empty box beside the window, and we watched an actual bird land outside. Nothing in that moment needed narration from the Director of Avian Relations. The bird looked in, considered the binder, and flew away with the understandable air of someone avoiding paperwork.

The game offered a boy, a bird, and a blur of ordinary life and imagination. I sat back. For once I could not improve the experience by selecting a more impressive sentence, which removed an entire category of trouble.

The actual attraction

A Bird Story is a short, wordless interactive animation about a boy and an injured bird. Its small scale and reliance on images make it distinct from the more dialogue-heavy games nearby. The developer explicitly presents it as an experiment, not To the Moon's sequel.

The catch worth knowing

Fewer words do not eliminate movement, interaction, or waiting through a deliberately authored sequence. The child-and-bird story still has emotional stakes. Check the ordinary controls and whether the amount of interaction matches what you want from a game tonight.

An opening invitation

Follow the first simple routine and observe how images communicate the relationship. Let the initial section show you its rhythm. If you want many decisions or extensive dialogue, use that preference to choose another page rather than forcing this one.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Welcomed after the bird established that a complete story can exist without answering any of my unnecessary questions.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected Steam primary description/category declarations for PC release. Premise and explicit features are supported; practical workload and routing are editorial judgments. No full-path input verification.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/327410/>

P183 / **CONDITIONAL** / directional input / pace: unknown / native co-op: no

OPUS: Rocket of Whispers

The Rocket Budget Contains a Line for Goodbye

Edition considered: PC release

I drafted a rocket budget with separate columns for propulsion, heroic photography, and ribbons. Tank asked where I had included the reason for launching it. I pointed at the word rocket. He waited until I understood the difference.

OPUS: Rocket of Whispers follows survivors gathering materials for a space burial. That purpose changed how the work felt. Shawna put the photograph budget aside. Some journeys did not need my face attached to their destination.

Rosa brought a battered tin from the cupboard. It held buttons collected from clothes she no longer owned. Each one had a small story. Mercedes listened while she named them, and I resisted the urge to classify the collection as inventory.

The game would ask us to explore and gather, not merely admire its snow. I wrote that down. Then I removed the ribbon line from the budget. Tank used the ribbon to tie the tin closed, a modest practical task that seemed, in the circumstances, exactly the right scale.

The actual attraction

Rocket of Whispers connects exploring a ruined snowy world with building a rocket to honor the dead. Objects found along the way reveal history as well as supplying materials. The gathering has an emotional purpose shared by the surviving characters.

The catch worth knowing

Expect travel, searching, equipment crafting, and keeping track of needed supplies. Plague aftermath, loss, and saying goodbye are central. The store's single-player description is explicit; two protagonists do not imply two-player control. Check navigation and repeated collection demands.

An opening invitation

Explore an early area and bring back one useful material or discovered story. Notice whether the search feels purposeful or repetitive. A strong emotional premise need not compensate for a gathering loop you do not enjoy.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Given launch consideration because this rocket has a reason to leave the ground that is better than my publicity photograph.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected Steam primary description/category declarations for PC release. Premise and explicit features are supported; practical workload and routing are editorial judgments. No full-path input verification.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/742250/>

P184 / **CONDITIONAL** / mixed input / pace: unknown / native co-op: unknown

OPUS: Echo of Starsong - Full Bloom Edition

The Asteroid Refuses to Sing My Anthem

Edition considered: PC Full Bloom Edition

I commissioned an office anthem so that important objects could announce my arrival. Tank said the printer already made a noise whenever I approached it. That was because I kept feeding the paper in crooked, but the timing was impressive.

Echo of Starsong imagined sounds from asteroids and a journey built around hearing, exploring, and interpreting them. I attempted to demonstrate with a glass and a spoon. Mercedes took the spoon away after the third note.

“The stars didn't request accompaniment.”

Shawna checked the edition. Full Bloom added voice acting, but our language still needed checking; the English interface did not magically turn every voice into English. I had been ready to promise that from the title alone.

Rosa dimmed the lamp so the screen's spaces felt larger. The game's journey also involved puzzles and resources, so we left room to inspect those. My anthem remained unfinished. Space had survived another threat to its silence.

The actual attraction

Full Bloom presents a voiced, visual-novel-style space adventure following Jun and Eda in search of mysterious starsongs. Their journey connects personal motives with conflict, ancient places, and other travelers. Music and the relationship between the leads are central attractions.

The catch worth knowing

The official page describes light puzzles and resource management alongside narrative scenes. English subtitles/interface are listed, while the checked full-audio languages are Japanese and Chinese. Check reading, exploration, and sound-puzzle presentation; the word accessible in marketing is not a complete control audit.

An opening invitation

Follow an early exchange, then inspect one exploration or travel decision. Confirm language settings and whether the sound-related information is presented in a usable way. Continue if the relationship interests you as much as the scenery.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Cleared for departure once the asteroid's musical independence was protected from my extremely local concept of a universal anthem.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Manually opened Steam app1504500 and verified exact Full Bloom Edition title, voice-language table, narrative/exploration/light puzzle/resource description. No full-path input verification.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1504500/>

P185 / CONDITIONAL / pointer input / pace: unknown / native co-op: unknown

I Was a Teenage Exocolonist

My Childhood Has Been Converted into a Deck

Edition considered: PC release

I made a card representing my greatest childhood achievement. It showed me looking magnificent beside a science project. Shawna asked who had built the project. I put the card back in the deck.

Exocolonist turns experiences into cards while a young person grows up in an alien colony. I immediately tried to combine NATURAL LEADERSHIP with UNLIMITED POTENTIAL. Tank laid down FORGOT LUNCH and won the exchange.

Rosa said growing up was allowed to include things that were not achievements. Mercedes added a card called LISTENED TO A FRIEND. Its artwork was simply an empty microphone stand. Everybody understood whom it concerned.

The game could connect relationships, study, exploration, and danger over years, which made the card system more than a decorative score. It also meant a lot of choices and consequences. I stopped promising a carefree childhood simulator. My own little deck had already exposed three unresolved stories and the fact that Tank had remembered everybody's sandwiches except mine, at my explicit instruction.

The actual attraction

This narrative roleplaying game follows ten formative years in an alien colony. Experiences become cards used in challenges, while activities and relationships influence the future. Its appeal is watching personal growth and a larger community's fate affect one another.

The catch worth knowing

Cards, skills, schedules, and branching relationships create substantial system and memory demands. The attractive watercolor setting includes danger, death, and difficult personal material. Inspect challenge rules and content information rather than treating a youthful cast as proof of lightness.

An opening invitation

Choose an early activity and learn one card challenge deliberately. Pay attention to a character whose company you enjoy. Decide whether the cards make your history feel meaningful or add a management layer you would prefer to avoid.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Admitted when a remembered conversation sounds like a better collectible than the gold certificate I printed for my own childhood.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected Steam primary description/category declarations for PC release. Premise and explicit features are supported; practical workload and routing are editorial judgments. No full-path input verification.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1148760/>

P186 / CONDITIONAL / pointer input / pace: mixed / native co-op: unknown

Growing Up

The Schedule Has Asked When I Plan to Grow Up

Edition considered: PC release

I produced a daily plan for my development. It contained eight hours of influence, two hours of mysterious availability, and a large space marked DESTINY. Tank wrote laundry in that space.

Growing Up offered a much more concrete schedule: activities, skills, friendships, school, and the gradual shape of a life. I asked whether the game would recognize innate greatness without making me attend anything. Shawna said that sounded like a request for a different genre.

Mercedes examined the illustrated nineties setting while Rosa remembered a terrible haircut with surprising affection. I tried to nominate my silver jacket as period evidence. Nobody accepted its historical credentials.

The game had many systems, which might be satisfying to someone who wanted to direct a life in detail. They were not automatically relaxing just because the illustrations were warm. I revised my plan to include one achievable task. Tank pointed at the laundry. Destiny, for that afternoon, had excellent stain-removal properties.

The actual attraction

Growing Up combines a coming-of-age story with choosing activities and developing skills. Friendships and family continuity give the schedules a narrative context, while its nineties setting offers a particular flavor of ordinary life and remembered ambitions.

The catch worth knowing

The primary description explicitly includes aptitude mini-games, exams, daily scheduling, many skills, and varied outcomes. This is a management-rich life game, not only dialogue. Check the mini-game inputs and whether balancing the systems feels enjoyable rather than like another planner.

An opening invitation

Set one early schedule, try its associated activity, and see how a friendship develops around it. Use the result to judge the management loop. There is no need to optimize a whole childhood before deciding whether you like playing one day.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Granted a developmental appointment after my personal growth plan finally contained a task that could be completed before dinner.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected Steam primary description/category declarations for PC release. Premise and explicit features are supported; practical workload and routing are editorial judgments. No full-path input verification.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1191120/>

P187 / CONDITIONAL / pointer input / pace: mixed / native co-op: unknown

Volcano Princess

The Royal Parent Has Lost the Activity Form

Edition considered: PC release

I offered to mentor the next monarch. Rosa asked whether I had watered the actual plant. I said leadership involved delegation. She handed me the watering can.

In Volcano Princess, raising a daughter connects activities and relationships to a fantasy kingdom's future. I tried to draft her entire life in advance. Mercedes read the document and asked where the person was supposed to go.

“She's at the center.”

“You've put your crest at the center.”

Shawna replaced the crest with a question: what seems interesting to her? That made our discussion immediately less ridiculous. It did not erase the game's schedules, stats, and outcomes, but it gave us a reason to look beyond winning an imaginary parenting tournament.

Tank found my activity form beneath the gold stamp. I had flattened it so thoroughly that the ink transferred onto the table. Rosa said the furniture was now better prepared for public office than I was. I completed my watering assignment before applying for any more responsibility.

The actual attraction

Volcano Princess mixes a fantasy coming-of-age story with arranging a daughter's activities, studies, and relationships. Different interests can lead toward different lives. The attraction is seeing a character develop through the choices and people around her.

The catch worth knowing

Menus, stats, planning, and multiple activity types are a substantial part of play. The story begins after a parent's death and includes conflict and combat-related training. Inspect each activity's controls and avoid treating the parenting premise as a simple conversation game.

An opening invitation

Choose one early activity and see how its result connects to a conversation or new opportunity. Check the calendar and character information together. Continue if guiding development is enjoyable without needing a supposedly perfect outcome.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Accepted for consideration after my mentorship proposal was reduced from hereditary glory to remembering what the person actually enjoyed.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected Steam primary description/category declarations for PC release. Premise and explicit features are supported; practical workload and routing are editorial judgments. No full-path input verification.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1669980/>

P188 / DETOUR / pointer input / pace: unknown / native co-op: unknown

Long Live The Queen

The Princess Has Survived My Advice Thus Far

Edition considered: PC release

I placed a small crown on the printer to establish a royal training environment. It jammed immediately. Tank said that was the most convincing succession crisis he had seen all week.

Long Live The Queen asks a young heir to prepare for a dangerous coronation. I offered a simple curriculum: confidence, posture, and advanced waving. Shawna opened the list of actual threats and invited me to reconsider.

Mercedes suggested that a game capable of killing its protagonist should not be introduced with the phrase a lovely princess afternoon. Rosa removed that phrase from my notes so firmly the paper tore.

The attraction here could be planning, discovering consequences, and trying another approach. That was a legitimate taste, but it was very different from wanting an undemanding conversation. I admitted the difference. Tank removed the crown and freed the printer's paper. Our own monarch had survived because somebody learned a practical skill, a detail I added to my curriculum in extremely small handwriting.

The actual attraction

Long Live The Queen makes preparation and choices the center of a perilous royal coming-of-age story. Learning which skills and decisions help the young heir survive can become a puzzle across attempts. It is an option for someone who actively enjoys that kind of consequence.

The catch worth knowing

The official premise emphasizes threats and survival. Skill planning, hidden consequences, and character death make this a deliberate detour rather than a low-pressure suggestion. Cute presentation does not soften the underlying challenge into a guaranteed easy evening.

An opening invitation

Inspect the training choices and follow an early consequence. Ask whether discovering how the system works is enjoyable even when an outcome goes badly. If avoiding punishing decisions is a hard preference, choose another story immediately.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Retained as a strategic detour because the printer's brief reign proved that a crown supplies neither competence nor immunity from a jam.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected Steam primary description/category declarations for PC release. Premise and explicit features are supported; practical workload and routing are editorial judgments. No full-path input verification.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/251990/>

P189 / CONDITIONAL / text input / pace: unknown / native co-op: unknown

Roadwarden

The Roadwarden Wants a Map Instead of a Title

Edition considered: PC release

I volunteered to connect isolated communities and issued myself a badge large enough to obstruct a doorway. Tank asked whether I knew the route. I said the badge would inspire local cooperation.

“Or get caught on a branch.”

Roadwarden's traveler needed information, supplies, and judgment in a dangerous peninsula. That was an admirable correction to my belief that entering a place confidently counted as preparation. Shawna asked me to name our next stop. I described a mood. She asked again.

Mercedes read a passage aloud and the room became a road, a settlement, a decision about whom to trust. Rosa put the badge down so it stopped scraping the table. The words were doing the traveling.

Choices still used time and resources inside the game. We could read slowly while the fictional journey remained demanding. I wrote the distinction on the back of my badge, making it useful for the first time. Tank approved it as an oversized note card with an unnecessary pin.

The actual attraction

Roadwarden offers a richly written fantasy journey through settlements, roads, and uncertain loyalties. Its text-based roleplaying combines conversation, inventory problems, survival, and discoveries about a particular place. The pleasure is becoming familiar with a world through attentive decisions.

The catch worth knowing

The source explicitly mentions hit points, survival mechanics, and quests restricted by in-game time. Reading at your own pace does not remove that strategic pressure. Expect substantial text and several tracked resources; inspect any typed-response or menu operations.

An opening invitation

Reach an early conversation or travel choice and identify what it costs in the game's systems. Make one decision because you are curious about its result. Judge whether the prose and the management work well together for you.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Granted road authority only after my badge contained directions instead of another decorative assertion that I was in charge.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected Steam primary description/category declarations for PC release. Premise and explicit features are supported; practical workload and routing are editorial judgments. No full-path input verification.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1155970/>

P190 / CONDITIONAL / text input / pace: unknown / native co-op: unknown

The Life and Suffering of Sir Brante

The Family Chronicle Has Redacted My Best Qualities

Edition considered: PC release

I began my family chronicle with the sentence AIDEN WAS BORN READY. Shawna asked ready for what. Tank suggested a nap. Mercedes suggested a rewrite. Rosa suggested that I leave enough room for other people to exist.

Sir Brante's life unfolds inside an oppressive order where birth and status carry enormous consequences. My sentence suddenly looked even less informative. I had made a whole life into an advertisement before allowing it a second paragraph.

I tried replacing ready with destined. Shawna took the pen.

The game's journal structure could make choices feel like marks on an entire history. It could also make the weight of consequences exactly the wrong company for a quiet evening. We would say both things.

Rosa handed the pen back and asked for a true sentence. I wrote that I had wanted to sound impressive. Tank nodded. "Now something can happen." It was an alarming amount of narrative progress from a line with no title, crest, or embossed border.

The actual attraction

This narrative roleplaying game follows a life within a harsh fantasy empire. Decisions, learned traits, family ties, and social position shape possible paths. It offers the pleasure of tracing how personal ambitions interact with an unjust and powerful order.

The catch worth knowing

The publisher calls it a hardcore narrative RPG and emphasizes costly consequences, oppression, death, and rebirth. Dense reading and long-term planning are central burdens. Treat it as a deliberate heavy-story option, not a gentle alternative simply because much of the action is written.

An opening invitation

Read an early chapter and inspect how one decision changes a relationship or trait. Decide whether you want to inhabit this society's pressures. You can value the writing without accepting the emotional weight of a full life inside it.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Kept on the serious shelf after my autobiography learned that a life needs actual people and consequences, not just flattering headings.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected Steam primary description/category declarations for PC release. Premise and explicit features are supported; practical workload and routing are editorial judgments. No full-path input verification.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1272160/>

P191 / CONDITIONAL / pointer input / pace: unknown / native co-op: unknown

Suzerain

The Republic of My Extremely Good Intentions

Edition considered: PC base game; Kingdom of Rizia expansion separate

I assumed the presidency of the office with a mandate to improve everything, especially the view of my portrait from the doorway. My first cabinet meeting concerned whether the snack budget should fund snacks or a photograph of me funding snacks.

Rosa voted for food. Tank voted for a chair that stopped making the sound of a submarine dying. Shawna placed three mutually incompatible promises in front of me and asked which one I intended to break. I requested a fourth promise, preferably one about listening.

Suzerain arrived with an entire country attached to the question. My campaign smile suddenly looked like something a printer had produced on its economy setting. People had interests, memories, livelihoods. They were not blank spaces waiting for my inspirational handwriting.

Mercedes removed the portrait. This improved the view considerably. I announced a historic transparency initiative and spent the remainder of the meeting admitting that I had not read the second page.

The actual attraction

As President Anton Rayne, you navigate Sordland's political institutions, economy, international relationships and family life. The attraction is sustained argument: people want incompatible things, and a policy decision can become a personal problem later.

The catch worth knowing

This is a dense reading and decision game with a codex, reports and many relationships to remember. Political violence and harsh outcomes add pressure. The inspected description does not establish every input's timing or hold requirements. This card covers the base game, excluding the Rizia expansion.

An opening invitation

Read the opening political setup and one conversation. Judge whether identifying factions feels intriguing or like an unwanted meeting. A companion can discuss priorities without supplying the supposedly correct ideology.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Approved for the evening you want to interrogate a minister; my portrait has already exercised its right to remain silent.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected primary product description supports the stated premise and features. Control-family, memory burden and recommendation are editorial assessments, not a complete accessibility audit. Timing or hold uncertainty is retained in the card. Exact PC edition only; source checked September 20, 2026.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1207650/>

P192 / CONDITIONAL / pointer input / pace: unknown / native co-op: unknown

Yes, Your Grace

The Throne Has Run Out of Biscuits

Edition considered: PC first game

I built my throne from two office chairs, which gave it twice the authority and an alarming tendency to swivel in opposite directions. Petitioners were invited to approach with any problem that could be solved by a confident expression.

Tank needed a working kettle. Rosa needed the snack cupboard replenished. Mercedes requested that I stop calling the hallway my northern province. I granted all three requests verbally and then discovered that verbal grants do not heat water.

In Yes, Your Grace, a king must hear requests while his resources remain inconveniently finite. I regarded this as a terrible design flaw in monarchy. Shawna regarded it as the beginning of accounting.

She placed four coins beside six requests and watched me arrange them into a more optimistic shape. The coins remained four. Eventually I climbed down from the throne to help with the kettle. Both chairs immediately became more useful, which Tank said was my strongest policy result.

The actual attraction

King Eryk hears petitioners, manages scarce resources and tries to protect his family and kingdom. Small requests sit beside larger alliances and threats, giving decisions an immediate human face rather than reducing everything to an abstract national graph.

The catch worth knowing

Resources run out, requests conflict and family decisions can hurt. The presentation includes strategic preparation and dangerous events; a throne screen is not a promise of carefree play. Verify the controls and pause behavior in the chosen PC version before assuming all situations wait.

An opening invitation

Hear the first petition and look at the resources attached to an answer. Ask whether saying no feels satisfyingly consequential or simply unpleasant. Stop without treating a difficult decision as something you must finish tonight.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Suitable when four coins and six requests sound like a story; unsuitable when you already chaired that meeting at breakfast.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected primary product description supports the stated premise and features. Control-family, memory burden and recommendation are editorial assessments, not a complete accessibility audit. Timing or hold uncertainty is retained in the card. Exact PC edition only; source checked September 20, 2026.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1115690/>

P193 / **CONDITIONAL** / pointer input / pace: unknown / native co-op: unknown

Orwell: Keeping an Eye On You

Aiden's Search History Requests Legal Representation

Edition considered: PC first game

I demonstrated my new surveillance department by projecting my own browser history onto the office wall. It included searches for ceremonial cape storage, affordable marble that looks expensive, and whether a person can trademark the concept of arriving.

'Strong case,' Tank said.

I explained that these fragments had been cruelly separated from context. Shawna asked what context could possibly improve the marble query. I said architectural ambition. Mercedes said plastic.

Orwell made the exercise less comfortable. A digital trace can be true and still create the wrong picture when somebody chooses which piece to pass along. My department's excellent equipment consisted of a mouse, a projector and an alarming amount of confidence in itself.

Rosa switched off the projector before the cape measurements appeared. I thanked her for respecting due process. She said she was respecting everyone else's lunch. We agreed that access to a detail does not automatically make its use wise.

The actual attraction

You investigate digital records for a state surveillance program and decide what information to submit. The pleasure lies in connecting messages, profiles and apparent contradictions, then noticing how your selection shapes somebody else's fate.

The catch worth knowing

Expect substantial reading, interface switching and memory for names and relationships. Surveillance, terrorism and personal intrusion are central themes. Selecting or transferring evidence needs a direct input check; the premise alone cannot certify mouse-only ease, no dragging or an absence of timed sections.

An opening invitation

Examine one person's available records and identify two details that might mean different things together. Before forwarding evidence, decide whether the ethical discomfort interests you. A companion can compare interpretations while one person operates the interface.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Approved for suspicious document readers, provided my search for a throne-sized lumbar cushion remains contextual evidence.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected primary product description supports the stated premise and features. Control-family, memory burden and recommendation are editorial assessments, not a complete accessibility audit. Timing or hold uncertainty is retained in the card. Exact PC edition only; source checked September 20, 2026.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/491950/>

P194 / CONDITIONAL / pointer input / pace: unknown / native co-op: unknown

Orwell: Ignorance is Strength

The Department of Technically Accurate Nonsense

Edition considered: PC sequel

After my first surveillance scandal, I established a communications office. Its inaugural headline was AIDEN PROVIDES UNPRECEDENTED SEATING. Underneath sat a photograph of the chair I had finally returned to the kitchen.

'Every word is true,' I said.

'And somehow the sentence is still lying,' Shawna replied.

Orwell: Ignorance is Strength understands that territory: information gains power through its placement, selection and use. I tried writing a correction that celebrated my commitment to corrections. Mercedes crossed out everything except RETURNED A CHAIR.

Tank wanted to know why the public needed a statement about a chair at all. This was a devastating question for an institution with an entire stationery drawer devoted to statements.

Rosa moved the drawer out of the kitchen and asked us to set the table. For once, a useful event occurred without a headline. I privately described it as a successful pilot of our low-visibility domestic infrastructure initiative, but I had the decency to keep that inside my head.

The actual attraction

This second Orwell story places you in a darker investigation shaped by political narratives and information manipulation. It can reward a reader who enjoys noticing how an apparently factual detail becomes a persuasive weapon.

The catch worth knowing

The official description introduces a time-of-day system and decisions about whom to investigate and when. That establishes scheduling pressure inside the story, not a verified real-time countdown or a no-timer guarantee. Expect dense records, unsettling politics and morally compromised work.

An opening invitation

Read the first assignment and inspect how the interface represents time before making several moves. Decide whether tracking opportunities sounds engaging. Discuss one competing interpretation with a companion without assuming the game offers a neutral choice.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

For evenings when a misleading headline makes you want to inspect its footnotes; my chair announcement has been withdrawn.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected primary product description supports the stated premise and features. Control-family, memory burden and recommendation are editorial assessments, not a complete accessibility audit. Timing or hold uncertainty is retained in the card. Exact PC edition only; source checked September 20, 2026.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/633060/>

P195 / CONDITIONAL / text input / pace: unknown / native co-op: unknown

Emily is Away

My Away Message Is Longer Than My Visit

Edition considered: PC first game

I prepared for Emily is Away by constructing a nostalgic online persona. My screen name contained three titles, two mysterious numbers and enough punctuation to make it look like a damaged shipping address.

Tank chose Tank. This struck me as an irresponsible refusal to develop a brand.

My away message announced that I was pursuing destiny beyond the limits of ordinary communication. Rosa looked through the doorway and found me searching for a clean spoon. Mercedes suggested a more accurate status: available, but being weird about it.

The game's instant-message window made small choices feel exposed. A short answer can carry all the things somebody is unwilling or unable to say. I began composing a magnificent explanation of why my fictional younger self deserved universal understanding.

Shawna tapped the screen. 'You're supposed to hear the other person too.' I deleted three paragraphs. Somewhere in the abandoned punctuation, a much more plausible conversation began to breathe.

The actual attraction

A simulated desktop and instant messenger frame a relationship across several years. Buddy profiles, changing circumstances and brief exchanges turn a familiar piece of technology into a story about growing apart, uncertainty and what people leave unsaid.

The catch worth knowing

Reading is central, and the messenger presentation includes keyboard interaction that should be tried directly. Do not assume every message is simply a pointer click or that arbitrary typing works identically across versions. Relationship regret may carry more weight than the small interface suggests.

An opening invitation

Choose a screen name and follow the first conversation far enough to feel its rhythm. Check the actual typing demand and text size. The useful question is whether the intimacy of messaging appeals, rather than whether you chose the best reply.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Recommended when an old away message can summon an entire era; my era apparently smelled of spoon polish and ambition.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected primary product description supports the stated premise and features. Control-family, memory burden and recommendation are editorial assessments, not a complete accessibility audit. Timing or hold uncertainty is retained in the card. Exact PC edition only; source checked September 20, 2026.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/417860/>

P196 / CONDITIONAL / pointer input / pace: unknown / native co-op: unknown

We Know the Devil

The Campfire Refuses My Team-Building Exercise

Edition considered: PC release

I announced a summer retreat for the office. Attendance was optional, although I had already embroidered everyone's names onto a banner reading TOGETHER WE VALIDATE AIDEN.

Mercedes inspected it. 'I opt out of the verb.'

We Know the Devil offered a much sharper picture of a group: three teenagers, a religious camp, and the way choosing closeness with one person can leave another outside. My icebreaker asked everybody to name a leadership quality they admired in me. The room became so silent that the printer's cooling fan sounded like weather.

Rosa took down the banner. Shawna replaced the exercise with a question anyone could decline to answer. Tank made a small campfire out of a battery lamp and some orange tissue paper, because he correctly distrusted my relationship with ceremonial flames.

I sat down without facilitating anything. Nobody applauded. The room improved anyway. It was an uncomfortable discovery for a man who had purchased a whistle specifically for fostering togetherness.

The actual attraction

This visual novel uses a small cast and a threatening camp setting to explore belonging, exclusion and queer identity. Which characters spend time together matters, creating room for conversation about relationships rather than inventory puzzles or navigation.

The catch worth knowing

Psychological horror, religious pressure, isolation and an alarming soundscape are integral to the experience. Light movement demands would not make the subject gentle. The inspected page supports its visual-novel form but does not independently verify every advance input or the absence of all timing demands.

An opening invitation

Read the opening exchange and listen to a short portion of the atmosphere at a comfortable volume. Decide whether this kind of unease is welcome before pursuing a route. Nobody owes the camp a complete visit.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Admitted for people curious about an unsettling triangle of loyalties; my whistle is not permitted within camp boundaries.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected primary product description supports the stated premise and features. Control-family, memory burden and recommendation are editorial assessments, not a complete accessibility audit. Timing or hold uncertainty is retained in the card. Exact PC edition only; source checked September 20, 2026.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/435300/>

P197 / CONDITIONAL / pointer input / pace: unknown / native co-op: unknown

A Normal Lost Phone

The Missing Phone Contains Fourteen Pictures of My Elbow

Edition considered: PC release

When somebody mentioned a found-phone mystery, I offered my own handset as a practice case. Its photographs consisted of my elbow, several meals I had forgotten to photograph until after eating them, and a blurry close-up of the gold stamp.

'We can establish one thing,' Shawna said. 'The suspect has never met a camera angle he understands.'

A Normal Lost Phone asks you to reconstruct a life from a fictional device. I started explaining that my contacts list revealed a complex network of influence. Tank showed us the entry for Kettle Guy, which was my own number from a failed repair appointment.

Rosa put the phone down. 'A real person's privacy isn't a party game.' The distinction held: this is a designed fictional investigation, with a story waiting behind its interface. My embarrassing photographs were merely an administrative failure. Mercedes deleted nothing, because evidence of my elbows deserved a fair hearing, however unflattering its composition.

The actual attraction

Messages, pictures and apps form a narrative investigation into Sam's life and disappearance. The appeal is close reading: an ordinary digital object gradually reveals relationships and circumstances that were invisible at first glance.

The catch worth knowing

The inspected Steam page says this game is no longer available on that store as of September 20, 2026. Existing access must be established before planning a session. Expect personal, potentially sensitive material, small interface details and searching across apps; the page does not certify input comfort.

An opening invitation

If you already have a legitimate playable copy, inspect one message thread and test the fictional phone's navigation. Ask whether piecing together a person's circumstances feels compelling, and stop before curiosity becomes an obligation to finish.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Provisionally welcome for digital archaeologists; the committee must first locate the game, unlike my elbow, which is exceptionally well documented.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Manually verified Steam app 523210 identifies A Normal Lost Phone and explicitly states it is no longer available on Steam, observed September 20, 2026. Premise comes from the product description. Existing access, controls and availability elsewhere are not established.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/523210/>

P198 / CONDITIONAL / pointer input / pace: unknown / native co-op: unknown

Another Lost Phone: Laura's Story

Laura's Calendar Declines an Interview with My Ego

Edition considered: PC release

For the second phone investigation, I proposed an improved method: reconstruct somebody's life from their calendar. My own calendar contained Breakfast Strategy, Lunch Strategy and an unexplained three-hour appointment called Become Unignorable.

Mercedes said the last event appeared to be recurring.

Another Lost Phone: Laura's Story invites attention to the gaps between a person's public routine and private circumstances. I spread coloured cards across the table, certain that enough organisation would make another life simple.

Shawna separated what the records actually said from what I had guessed. Half my impressive diagram moved into the second pile. Tank added a third pile labelled AIDEN LIKES ARROWS. It was distressingly large.

Rosa asked what Laura might need us to notice, rather than what would make us feel clever. That question rearranged the whole table without a single new arrow. I cancelled Become Unignorable and scheduled Listen. Then I removed the alarm, since apparently listening was allowed to continue beyond its appointment.

The actual attraction

A fictional found phone holds Laura's photographs, messages and apps. Following connections between professional life, relationships and social habits creates a story through investigation rather than through moving an avatar around a large landscape.

The catch worth knowing

Expect close reading, app navigation, inference and difficult personal circumstances. The official game site verifies the premise, while a retailer verifies this PC edition; neither settles every control demand or current availability elsewhere. Automated Steam matches were wrong, so those unrelated products are excluded from this card.

An opening invitation

Start by examining the fictional phone layout and a short exchange. Compare an observation with an interpretation, keeping them separate. Decide whether the interface is legible and the personal investigation welcome before following every available thread.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Approved for readers who enjoy understanding a story through its ordinary details; the committee's decorative arrows have been placed on unpaid leave.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Official game site anotherlostphone.com is credited to Accidental Queens and directly describes the narrative investigation, phone apps, friendships, professional life and disappearance. GameHouse separately verifies the PC title. Incorrect automated Steam matches were excluded. Neither source certifies full-path timing or holds; checked September 20, 2026.

Source 1: <https://anotherlostphone.com/>

Source 2: <https://www.gamehouse.com/games/another-lost-phone-lauras-story>

P199 / CONDITIONAL / pointer input / pace: unknown / native co-op: unknown

Slay the Princess - The Pristine Cut

A Narrator with a Very Suspicious Job Description

Edition considered: PC Pristine Cut

I read the instruction aloud: go to the basement, deal with the princess, trust the narrator. This sounded wonderfully efficient to a man who routinely wrote his own glowing minutes.

Shawna asked why anyone should trust the narrator. I pointed at my official speaking jacket. Tank pointed at the fact that I had named it myself.

Slay the Princess made the dispute much less cosy. A voice can sound certain while the person listening has good reasons to question the assignment. I attempted to restore order with a sentence beginning Obviously. Mercedes stopped me before the second word.

Rosa said we could simply decline an evening of horror. This had not appeared anywhere in my dramatic briefing, because I had been busy choosing the basement font.

I rewrote the invitation. It now described the disturbing material and let people decide. The speaking jacket remained on its hanger, where its claims to moral authority could trouble only the spare umbrella and one exceptionally sceptical moth.

The actual attraction

The Pristine Cut expands a fully voiced psychological-horror visual novel whose branching story turns on what you do, believe and question. Narration, performance and shifting interpretations are major attractions for somebody who enjoys arguing with a story's apparent authority.

The catch worth knowing

The developer explicitly warns of intense violence, gore, partial nudity, strong language and suicide themes. This is a substantial content catch, not a gentle princess tale. Full voice acting does not establish no timed or held inputs; check the exact interface before making that assumption.

An opening invitation

Read the content notice first. If the premise still appeals, hear the initial narration and inspect how dialogue advances. Choose whether to continue for its argument and atmosphere, without accepting the narrator's urgency as your own.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

A conditional invitation for people who enjoy a sinister voice being challenged; my jacket failed the narrator-trust examination on sight.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Manually verified exact Steam title Slay the Princess - The Pristine Cut, app 1989270. Publisher description supports branching fully voiced psychological horror and expanded Pristine Cut; developer mature-content notice supplies the explicit content catches. No full-playthrough timing or hold audit.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1989270/>

P200 / CONDITIONAL / pointer input / pace: waits / native co-op: unknown

Scarlet Hollow

The Family Reunion Has an Unscheduled Creature

Edition considered: PC episodic release; current completion status must be checked

I arranged a perfectly normal family gathering on behalf of Scarlet Hollow. The seating chart accounted for old grievances, difficult conversations and one cousin who might bring an inexplicable object.

Tank asked why there was a place marked CRYPTID. I said good hospitality anticipated unusual guests. Rosa agreed about hospitality but asked why the cryptid had a better chair than everybody else.

The game combines a funeral visit, strained family ties and a town with deeply unwelcome mysteries. I selected personal traits for my fictional host, starting with Unmatched Charisma. Shawna asked whether a game actually offered that trait or whether I was filling in my own publicity again.

Mercedes chose a chair where she could see the door. I revised my seating chart to include a clear exit for anybody who disliked the horror. The cryptid never arrived, but my aunt's silence about the potato salad developed an atmosphere powerful enough to qualify for its own soundtrack.

The actual attraction

Character traits and choices shape a branching horror mystery around a family visit and a troubled town. Conversations can reveal different details, making personality and relationships part of the investigation rather than merely decoration around clues.

The catch worth knowing

The inspected description lists five available episodes and another major update before the conclusion as of September 20, 2026: this is unfinished. The developer declares no jumpscare and Steam lists play without timed input, but disturbing imagery and tension remain. Neither statement certifies every hold or device.

An opening invitation

Inspect the opening traits and read the first family exchange. Decide whether you want a tense serial whose ending is still pending. A companion can debate impressions while the person playing keeps authority over the actual choices.

Aiden's entirely unnecessary ruling

Admitted for readers who welcome an ominous family visit and can tolerate a story still arriving; the cryptid gets an ordinary chair.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Matched Steam publisher description on September 20, 2026 says five episodes available and another major update before the conclusion. Developer states no jumpscare; the Steam category declares playable without timed input. Those are sourced declarations, not a complete no-hold or no-distress certification.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1609230/>

The Office Closes When the Guest Leaves

I had reserved the final hour for a grand address on the transformative power of narrative. The heading occupied half a page. Beneath it I had written REMEMBER TO BE HUMBLE in letters large enough to be read from the corridor.

Mercedes found it while looking for a clean sheet.

“You scheduled humility?”

“Otherwise it gets crowded out.”

“By what?”

I glanced at the microphone. She nodded as if that completed the paperwork.

Instead of the address, Rosa asked everybody what they actually wanted to return to. The answers were not a ranking. One person wanted another conversation at a counter. Another wanted a difficult political decision precisely because it was difficult. Somebody wanted a strange town. Somebody else had had enough reading and wanted dinner. Nobody had failed the afternoon by choosing dinner.

Tank named one character he liked and one menu he disliked. That was more useful than my twelve-column experience matrix. Shawna wrote the two observations on a small card. We could act on them. We could try a different game, make a short next-step note, or return another day. We did not need to invent a permanent identity for a person from one evening's taste.

I looked at the binder. Forty stories sat in this part of it, and each contained more lives, choices, and complications than any summary could comfortably hold. The book could point toward a door. It could tell you whether there appeared to be stairs behind it. It could admit when we had not inspected the stairs. It could not make you enjoy the room.

That was a smaller job than the one I had advertised. It was also an honest one.

Shawna began stacking the chairs. I stopped her after the second.

“Leave one.”

She waited.

“If somebody wants to keep going.”

We left the screen where it was, the water beside it, and the route note within reach. There was no ceremony of completion. A conversation could remain unfinished without becoming a debt. A game could be abandoned without insulting its creator. The office could still contain an open book after the person who opened it had decided to do something else.

Rosa handed me the sign. I UNDERSTAND still glittered across it in deeply unnecessary gold.

“What do you want to do with this?”

I turned it over. The back was plain white. With a marker, I wrote TELL ME MORE.

Mercedes studied it. “Better.”

Tank added OR DON'T beneath it.

That was the part that made it work.

We carried the oranges into the kitchen. I took the gold microphone with us because it turned out to be an excellent weight for holding down the corner of a curling recipe. My understanding finally had a practical assignment. It did not speak once.

The red stapler stayed at the window until the evening cooled. Then Shawna closed the window, picked it up, and put it beside the binder. Nothing was permanently fixed. Everything necessary remained within reach.

An index with no authority over you

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Credits, source limits and the paperwork we actually mean

Creative direction: Nolan. Original Panorama prose, system design, research compilation and production: ChatGPT. A new companion experiment using the user-directed Ten Toes Down characters; the existing novels remain intact. Dedicated to Lillian and to the pleasure of finding something worth another turn.

Voice sources sampled: the revised Ten Toes Down six-book edition, especially Book I's funeral opening and Book II's academy arrival, plus the repository editorial record. Repository snapshot: 4f38948aa5fa97f294adfa74a0b7055c399b2826. The complete novels were not reread line by line for this project.

The optional traits, tokens and signed-dice layer take inspiration from Fate. The Panorama's catalogue coordinates, vetoes, snack amendment, incidents and appeals are original comic selection rules; this is not a substitute for the Fate rulebooks.

Fate reference pages consulted:

<https://fate-srd.com/fate-accelerated/how-do-stuff-outcomes-actions-and-approaches> and <https://fate-srd.com/fate-accelerated/aspects-fate-points>. No Fate logos, illustrations or fonts are used.

This work is based on Fate Core System and Fate Accelerated Edition, products of Evil Hat Productions, LLC, developed, authored, and edited by Leonard Balsera, Brian Engard, Jeremy Keller, Ryan Macklin, Mike Olson, Clark Valentine, Amanda Valentine, Fred Hicks, and Rob Donoghue, and licensed for our use under the Creative Commons Attribution 3.0 Unported license (<https://creativecommons.org/licenses/by/3.0/>).

Game titles identify the corresponding games. No game code, ROMs, full manuals or third-party artwork are included. Availability and controls can vary by edition, region and platform. The sources support their stated claims; no purchase, installation or personal fit has been established by this book.

Each case names its inspected sources and the limits of those sources. Store descriptions and developer feature declarations are not a playthrough of every route. The companion evidence ledger records editorial tags separately from source declarations. Availability and features may change after the check date.